

Drifting jellies

Most of the animals that drift in the sunlit zone as zooplankton are tiny and almost weightless. But some are much bigger. They include jellyfish and unusual creatures such as comb jellies and salps. Although many can swim to some extent, they drift with the currents, feeding on the smaller animals as well as on each other. Some even catch fish.

Bell-shaped body is mostly made of springy jelly

STINGING TENTACLES

Many jellyfish live among the plankton. As they drift with the current, they swim by contracting their circular bodies to push water behind them and drive themselves along. They trail long, almost invisible tentacles armed with microscopic stinging cells, snaring and paralyzing other animals, which they can then reel in and eat. Some are giants—more than 6 ft (1.8 m) wide.

FLOATING KILLER

The notoriously venomous Portuguese man-of-war may look like a jellyfish, but it is made up of a collection of animals that live together. Each has a specific job: one is the float with a sail that makes it drift in the wind, while others gather food, produce young, or defend the colony.

► LION'S MANE JELLYFISH

One of the biggest jellyfish, this oceanic drifter can have venomous tentacles more than 98 ft (30 m) long.

